

Columbia Animal Hospital everything I need to know

1409 Hwy 98E · (601) 736-3041 · Mon–Fri 7:30–5:30, Sat 8:00–12:00. Dr. Pat Sanford (owner, since 1985) · Dr. Janelle Loper (2008) · Dr. Bridgett Williams (2013).

THE PITCH

Renovation, not rescue

They just renovated the building. That is the whole angle — and it beats every other one, because it is a compliment with a gap in it and nobody gets defensive about it.

"Y'all just did the renovations — place looks great. I do websites, and I noticed the site hasn't caught up with the building yet. So I went ahead and built what it could look like. Can I show you? It's got your doctors on it."

- **Never say they are losing clients.** Columbia has exactly two vet practices and this is the bigger one. Everyone already knows where they are. Claim a problem they do not have and a man who has run this place since 1985 knows instantly that I do not understand his business.
- **I am finishing something they started**, not fixing something broken.
- **Show before I talk.** Open the laptop, turn it round, shut up. They will recognise their own doctors and their own sign. That does the selling.
- **Today is not the sale.** Today is a name and a good time to come back.

THEM

Facts I should have straight

The practice

- Since 1975. Small-animal exclusive since 2005.
- Three veterinarians, about eleven staff in the team photo.
- Surgery, dental, x-ray, heartworm, dermatology, reproductive, grooming, boarding, microchipping.
- **303 Google reviews.** Twelve of the best are on the site I built.
- Their own on-call vet after hours — not in the Hattiesburg emergency network.

The market

- Columbia ~6,000 people. Marion County ~24,000, about 9,100 households.
- **Only one other clinic in town** — Marion Pet Care, appears to be a single vet. Everything else is 22+ miles.
- Hattiesburg is 34 miles and has around 30 practices. That is where anything "advanced" leaks to.
- Median household income \$45,110 county, \$38,507 city. Money is not loose here.

MONEY

The price, and what they pay now

- **\$3,500 once, and the site is theirs.** Half on signature, half the day it goes live.
- **\$75 a month afterwards, optional.** Hosting, backups, updates, changes. Cancel any month, or decline it and host it themselves.
- **Included:** every old page redirected, the domain pointed, the sitemap submitted, the wrong listings corrected. **Not included:** photography.
- **They almost certainly pay nothing today.** Their site sits on vetsourcecms.com, and Vetsource makes its money on pharmacy margin — no enrolment fee, no monthly charge, no cancellation fee. **I cannot win this on price and should not try.**
- **The line that kills the objection before it lands:** they can keep the Vetsource pharmacy and still own a proper website. The two are separable.

THE BIG ONE

"It's out of our budget"

A practice with three vets in a town this size is not literally unable to find \$3,500. So this sentence almost always means something else. **Do not discount in the room.** Dropping the price at the first push teaches them the price was never real, and invites a second push.

"Totally fair. Is it the number, or is it the timing?"

One question, and it splits into the two answers that need completely different responses.

If they say *timing* — that is likely true here

- They just spent money on the renovation. Believe them.
- **Move the payments, not the price.** Offer thirds — about \$1,170 a month across three months. Same total, fits a different cash-flow month.
- Or set a start date rather than a discount: *"Want me to hold this and start in January?"*
- Ask when their budget year turns over. That gives me a date and a reason to come back that is theirs, not mine.

If they say *the number* — it is a value conversation, not a price one

- **Anchor against what they just spent.** A building renovation runs to tens of thousands. Every client walks through the website before they walk through the door, usually on a phone. It is the one room that did not get touched.
- **Cut scope, never the rate.** Fewer pages, they supply the photographs, they do their own listing corrections. Less work for less money is honest. The same work for less money is not.
- **My floor is \$2,500.** Below that I am working for free and teaching a client that my numbers are soft.
- Compare to what a vet-specific vendor charges: VIN's eVetSites is \$109–\$169 a *month*, forever, and they never own it. Three years of that is \$4,000–\$6,000 and they still have nothing.

If it is really a no

- Take it gracefully and leave the sheet. *"No problem at all — I'll leave this with you in case it comes up later."*
- A no today is not a no forever, and the site does not expire.
- **Never argue.** The one thing that turns a "not right now" into a "never" is a stranger pushing.

ALSO

Other things they might say

- **"We already have a website."** — "You do, and it works. It is just built on a platform VetSource does not really sell any more, and it was laid out before everybody moved to phones." Never say theirs is bad.
- **"Who did you say you are with?"** — "Just me. I live here in town." Local is the whole advantage; do not dress it up as an agency.
- **"Where did you get our doctors' photos?"** — From what the practice already publishes. Nothing goes live until they say so, and consent for everyone shown is on the pre-launch list in writing.

- **"Will we lose our Google ranking?"** — No. Every old address redirects to its new page. That is included, not an extra.
- **"Send me something."** — Yes, and do it that day. The thirteen-page version exists for exactly this.
- **"That's not my call."** — "I know. Who is, and when are they usually around?" That is the whole goal today anyway.

ASK

Questions, not statements

Whoever is at the desk lives every problem on my list. Ask, and they tell me — then it goes back to Dr. Sanford as something a staff member raised, not something a salesman claimed.

- "Do y'all ever get people showing up Saturday morning before you open?" *Three directories say 7:30, they open at 8:00.*
- "When somebody calls after hours — what happens? Where do they find that number?" *The strongest card. A care problem, not a marketing one.*
- "How much of the phone is people asking things already written down somewhere?"
- "If y'all ever wanted to move the website, do you know what you'd be able to take with you?" *Do not answer it. Leave it with them.*
- "Who handles the website now — does the office pay for that, or does it come with the Vetsource account?"
- "Is Dr. Carson still with y'all?"

Every one of these can be dropped. "I noticed X — does that cause y'all any trouble?" and if the answer is no, move on.

POCKET

Findings — for later, not the opener

- Marion County Development Partnership lists **1498** Hwy 98 East. US Companies lists **Old** Hwy 98 E. Both wrong.
- Three directories put Saturday at **7:30**; they open at 8:00.
- The whole site is also live at *columbiaanimalhospital.vetsourcecms.com*, so search engines split the credit between two copies.
- Their site says a vet is available after hours and **never says how to reach one**. One old review claims they stopped doing after-hours entirely — worth checking, carefully.
- Four reviews mention **walk-ins**, two of them recent. Neither website says so anywhere. That is a selling point they are sitting on.
- A separate Yelp listing exists under "Carson Wallace DR" at their address.
- People searching for them land on the **Pennsylvania** practice's review pages.
- **Front desk is the recurring criticism in their reviews**. Do not raise it with whoever is at that desk. Ever.

GET

What I need to find out today

- **Look at the sign in the car park.** The building photo on the site reads 903-234-0869 with a single-dog logo. If the real sign does not match, take a phone photo from the road — that fixes two slots.
- Dr. Wallace Carson — still there, retired, or gone?
- How a client actually reaches the on-call vet.
- Saturday opening time, confirmed.
- The Google star rating, and their listing link.
- Whether the office pays anything for the website today.

CAREFUL

Don't

- × **Don't run down their current site in front of staff.** Somebody in that building may have picked it.
- × **Don't leave the thirteen-page version.** One sheet. The long one is for when they ask.
- × **Don't discount to keep the conversation alive.**
- × **Don't ask for the doctor's cell number.**
- × **Don't pitch "more clients".** They do not have that problem.
- × **Don't linger.** Be the person who was easy, not the one who would not leave.

If Dr. Sanford walks out himself

Same opening. Hand him the laptop and let him scroll. When he asks the price, say it plainly — **\$3,500, once, and the site is his**, \$75 a month afterwards only if he wants it looked after — then stop talking. First one to fill the silence loses.

Anything I do not know: **"I don't know, let me find out."** He has run that practice for forty years and will spot a bluff instantly. The other answer he will respect.

After

- Write the name and the good time down in front of them.
- Thank them and go.
- **Follow up Monday.** Cold deals close on the second or third visit, almost never the first.
- The floor today: somebody says "leave it with me", I say thanks, I walk out. Nothing bad happens. Nothing I have now is at risk.